PAKISTAN

SHAHEEN I, II AND III

Pakistan's top ballistic missiles for nuclear deterrence. While Shaheen I is a Short Range Ballistic Missile (SRBM), II and III are MRBMs that cover most Indian strategic targets

RANGE: 750-900 km, 1,500-2000 km and 2,750 km respectively

ABABEEL

Nuclear-capable ballistic missile with MIRV technology

RANGE: 2,200 km

ABDALI

SRBM for battlefield and tactical targets

RANGE: 200–450 km



Fatah-II

GHAZNAVI

SRBM for tactical strikes

RANGE: 300 km

RA'AD ALCM

Indigenous, nuclear-capable air-launched cruise missile

RANGE: 350–600 km

NASR

Short-range, nuclear-capable ballistic missile for 'quick response' strikes

RANGE: 70 km

FATAH-I & II

Guided multiple launch rocket systems for deep strikes

RANGE: 140 km & 400 km, respectively

CHINA

DF-27, DF-31 & DF-41

China's three ICBMs offer it strategic nuclear deterrence, with DF-41 having global nuclear strike capability

RANGES: 5,000-8,000 km, 7,000-11,000 km and 12,000+ km respectively

DF-21

MRBM for precision land attacks; anti-ship variant known as 'carrier killer'

RANGE: 1,500–2,150 km

DF-11

SRBM ideal for precision strikes against airfields, troop concentrations

RANGE: 300–600 km

DF-17

China's hypersonic (speeds of Mach 5+) MRBM that is difficult to intercept by missile defence systems

RANGE: 1,800–2,500 km



DF-17

responsible for both nuclear-capable missiles and conventional long-range strike operations. Its inventory includes intercontinental ballistic missiles, intermediate- and medium-range systems and advanced hypersonic weapons. They provide China with the capability to conduct precision conventional strikes across the Indo-Pacific while maintaining a credible nuclear deterrent.

'FORCE DUPLICATION'

Lt Gen. Shankar believes India possesses the nucleus of a future deep-strike force in its three artillery divisions, which integrate artillery pieces, rocket systems, BrahMos and other missiles and established command-and-control networks. Rather than creating a separate missile force, he advocates expanding these formations with newer long-range missiles, precision munitions, UAVs and joint-service staffing.

Gen. Shankar also proposes increasing the number of artillery divisions from the existing three to nine—four facing China, two towards Pakistan, one for the Andaman and Nicobar Command and two more for the mainland. "What India needs is an integrated DRAM—Drones, Rockets, Artillery and Missiles—ecosystem networked through ISR (intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance) and joint theatre commands. The objective should be deep-strike dominance, not organisational duplication," he says.

Similarly, Lt Gen. Anil K. Ahuja, former army corps commander and an artillery officer, believes a missile force would require substantial logistical investments that could be directed towards expanding missile/ rocket inventories. He advocates more coordination between the army and the IAF on long-range missile strike roles through clearer allocation of responsibilities. "The debate should not be about creating a missile force for its own sake, but about generating maximum long-range strike capability at the lowest organisational cost," Lt Gen. Ahuja concludes.

Even Clary believes that an integrated rocket force is not necessary for India at this stage. Most militaries, he reiterates, distribute strike capabilities across traditional services and rely on joint targeting mechanisms to coordinate their use. "An integrated force would only make sense if such joint processes were failing or if the senior leadership felt the services were not prioritising long-range strike capabilities," Clary says.

While the government seems keen on a missile force, experts are divided on the issue. All, however, agree that India's rocket/ missile forces need constant expansion through newer indigenous systems. ■